

A Small Test Book

Ada Example

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1 Start With the Customer

Talk to ten customers before you write any code. Ask what they did the last time the problem hurt, not what they would buy. Answers about past behaviour are far more reliable than any promise about the future, and they cost you nothing but an afternoon. Keep asking until the answers stop surprising you.

Write down each conversation the same day. Patterns only show up when you can compare notes across interviews, and memory quietly rewrites what people said. A shared document with one page per interview is enough for the first month.

2 Hire Slowly

Hire slowly and only when the pain of not hiring is obvious to everyone. Every early hire changes the culture more than any document you write about it, so the first ten people decide what the company will feel like for years.

Check references by calling people the candidate did not list. The best signal is how former teammates describe working with them during a bad week, when the plan failed and nobody knew what to do next.

3 Charge Early

Charge from the first customer, even if the price is small. Payment is the only honest signal that the problem matters, and a customer who pays tells you what is missing far more directly than one who is using the product for free.

Raise prices before you think you are ready. Most early teams undercharge because they confuse the discomfort of asking with the value they deliver to the buyer.

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